

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE · CONFIDENTIAL — FOR FAMILY
REVIEW



The Architecture of Grace

BOOK FOUR · THE FAÇADE

Home Edition

FOR FAMILIES · GRADES 9–10

The complete year-long curriculum — every lesson,
undiluted — re-engineered for delivery by a parent at
home, one conversation at a time.

FREE PREVIEW

This free preview includes the parent's opening letter, how to use the book, the
crisis & safety quick-reference, and the first complete lesson — read it end to end.
The full 4 units · 28 lessons are available in the Store.

Before You Begin

A letter to the parent of a child in grades 3, 4, or 5

This book hands you the entire Architecture of Grace · Façade curriculum — the grades 9–10 year — **nothing simplified, nothing left out.** In school a teacher runs these lessons with a class. Here you are the guide — but at this age, the most useful version of you is a steady consultant, not an instructor. Your teen is months from real independence. The work happens sideways now: in the car, over a late snack, on their terms and their timing.

By 14 or 15, the Mask has become a brand. Your teen now curates a self the way a company curates an image — and this year names the hidden cost of that, what the curriculum calls the **Performance Tax**. For autistic teens the bill is steeper: years of masking to “pass” can harden into a façade so complete that even they lose the thread of who’s underneath — and the exhaustion has a name, **autistic burnout**, which can land hard in exactly these years. This book is about the gap between the brand and the real person, and the cost of keeping it wide.

WHAT WE NEED TO TELL YOU — DIRECTLY

Grades 9–10 sit inside the highest-risk window of adolescence, and autistic teens carry markedly elevated risk for self-harm and suicidal thinking — driven by burnout, masking, social exhaustion, and rejection sensitivity, not by autism itself. It can look like a collapsing social life, flat affect, irritability, a dropped “whatever,” or sudden withdrawal. If your teen signals — in words, writing, or behavior — that they don’t want to be here, take it seriously the first time. Don’t debate it. Get help.

A few things this book asks of you:

- ◆ **Honor the Social Battery as real, not a mood.** Energy for social performance is finite, and for autistic teens it drains faster and refills slower. The kid who needs to be alone after school isn't rejecting you — they're recharging. Protect that, don't pathologize it.
- ◆ **Let the brand drop at home.** Home should be the one place the Performance Tax stops — where stimming, info-dumping, blunt honesty, and silence are all just... allowed. A teen who can unmask somewhere is a teen who can keep going.
- ◆ **Consult; don't correct.** At this age a head-on "lesson" bounces. A question offered sideways, with room to not answer, lands. Their growing autonomy is the goal, not the obstacle.
- ◆ **Their independence is coming — build the scaffolding now.** This book is, quietly, preparation for leaving. The skills here — integrity anchors, boundaries, self-compassion — are the load-bearing ones for adult life.
- ◆ **When a lesson is bigger than you — say so.** "This one's heavy. Let's bring in your counselor." That isn't failing. It models exactly what this curriculum teaches.

ONE MORE THING

You are not failing if your teen keeps you at arm's length, deflects, or says this is pointless. Independence requires some distance. You are still the floor under their feet. You are reading this. You are trying. That is the work.

ORIENTATION

How to Use This Book

A flip book — one complete lesson per spread, in any order you like

There are **28 lessons** across 4 units, mirroring the school year. Don't feel bound to the order. Open to a lesson, read it once, and let it surface over the week — sideways, in the ordinary moments, never as a summoned "talk." At this age, the indirect approach is not just gentler; it's the one that actually works.

Every lesson is built from the same six parts — once you know the shape of one, you know all 28:

① CORE DIRECT INSTRUCTION — HOME DELIVERY

The actual school lesson — objective, concepts, and steps intact — rewritten for one child and one adult at home, in real conversation rather than a scheduled block.

② THE AUTISM LENS

Three fixed supports: Make It Literal & Concrete, Sensory Regulation (matched to the lesson's emotional load), and Universal Design for Communication — so the lesson works whether your child speaks, types, uses AAC, points, or draws.

③ ELITE CONVERSATION STARTERS

Low-pressure, one-question prompts tagged to the natural moments of a day — each paired with a script to model on yourself first.

④ PRINTABLE VISUAL ASSETS & CHARTS

Ready-to-print anchor charts and home tools — fridge-and-binder versions of the classroom's visuals.

▲ SAFETY & ESCALATION

On every lesson: a clear line for when to bring in a professional. On high-stakes lessons this band grows — and tells you plainly when a conversation belongs to your child's counselor, not to you alone.

◆ PARENT REFLECTION

One private question after each lesson. Not homework. A place to put what the lesson stirred up — because it will.

IF YOU ONLY HAVE THREE MINUTES

Read the Crisis & Safety page next. Then read Lesson 1 (Beyond the Brand — the Performance Tax) and Unit 2, Lesson 6 (The Compassionate Witness). Those three pages are the spine of the whole year.

QUICK REFERENCE · KEEP THIS PAGE VISIBLE

If You Need Help Right Now

Crisis & safety numbers — fill in the local line before you ever need it

988	Suicide & Crisis Lifeline — call or text · 24/7 · free
741741	Crisis Text Line — text HOME · for when speaking isn't possible
911	Immediate danger. If you can, ask for a CIT-trained officer and say your child is autistic.
—	Your local mobile crisis line — write it here now: _____

A NOTE ON CALLING 911

Police interactions can be dangerous for autistic people if officers are not trained. When possible, call mobile crisis, your pediatrician, or 988 first. Reserve 911 for immediate physical danger.

FOR THE PARENT OF AN AUTISTIC CHILD

In the 3–5 years, distress often shows as withdrawal, shutdown, somatic complaints, or a sudden change — not the words “I feel sad.” Watch the whole child. When in doubt, ask your pediatrician or counselor. You are never overreacting by checking.

UNIT ONE



The Authentic Self • Identity & the Façade

By high school the curated self has become a brand, maintained at a real and rising cost. Unit 1 names that cost — the Performance Tax — maps the Social Battery that fuels it, builds an Integrity Anchor of genuine values, and locates authenticity on a spectrum rather than an all-or-nothing switch. It ends with the Identity Shield: a navigational document, not a finished portrait.

AUGUST – OCTOBER • SEVEN LESSONS

UNIT 1 • LESSON 1 • HOME EDITION

Beyond the Brand

★ SENSITIVE • PRIVATE

The gap between your curated self and your real self has a cost — the Performance Tax

OBJECTIVE

Your teen can explain the gap between the curated persona and the authentic self, and begin to measure what maintaining it costs them.

CASEL FOCUS

Self-Awareness — identity, persona, and the cost of the gap

VOCABULARY

curated self · authentic self · brand · the performance tax · gap

AT HOME

45–50 min · August · Personal — keep it private

① Core Direct Instruction — Home Delivery

- 1 **NAME THE GAP · 10 MIN** “By now you don’t just wear a mask — you run a brand. A version of you curated for each audience. That’s not always bad. The question isn’t whether you curate — it’s what the gap between the curated you and the real you is costing.”
- 2 **THE PERFORMANCE TAX · 8 MIN** “This curriculum calls that cost the **Performance Tax**. The wider your gap, and the longer you hold it, the more it consumes — energy, focus, the sense of who you actually are. The tax isn’t free, and you’ve been paying it without an itemized bill.”
- 3 **WHERE ARE YOU SPENDING MOST? · 7 MIN** Privately: “Where am I performing the hardest — which audience, which setting costs me the most to maintain?” No sharing required.
- 4 **IS THE GAP WORTH IT? · 6 MIN** “Not all curation is a problem — choosing what to share with a teacher isn’t a false self. But some gaps cost more than they’re worth. Name one you might narrow, in one safe place.”

② The Autism Lens

- ◆ **Make It Literal & Concrete** “Be authentic” is useless; the **Performance Tax** makes the cost **literal and measurable** — a tax you pay, in a currency (energy) you can feel. For autistic teens, masking is often the single most exhausting thing they do all day; naming it as a quantifiable cost, not a moral flaw, is the entire point.
- ◆ **Sensory Regulation — tied to this theme** This is the autism lesson of the book. Masking is relentless and, long-term, dangerous — a direct line to burnout. **Make home the place the brand switches off:** stimming, monologuing about a special interest, dropping eye contact, going nonverbal for a while — all of it the authentic self, all of it welcome. Keep this private; a teen whose gap is huge may be carrying real shame underneath.
- ◆ **Universal Design for Communication Write, type, or keep it internal.** Never collected, never required to share. “One word” answers count; AAC and drawing count.

③ Elite Conversation Starters

CAR “Which version of you is the most **work** to keep up all day? What does running it cost you?”

AT HOME “You never have to run the brand with me. This is where it gets to switch off.”

MEALTIME Model: “There’s a polished version of me I perform at work. Keeping that gap wide **taxes** me. Home is where I stop paying it.”

PARENT SCRIPT — MODEL IT ON YOURSELF

"Honestly, I run a curated version of myself at work all day — agreeable, unbothered, 'fine.' The gap between that and the real me costs me real energy; by evening I'm wiped, and that's the Performance Tax. Home is the one place I stop paying it. I want that to be true for you here too."

④ Printable Visual Assets & Charts

THE CURATED SELF VS. THE AUTHENTIC SELF

THE GAP BETWEEN THEM IS THE PERFORMANCE TAX **THE CURATED SELF · THE BRAND** Performed for an audience Managed, edited, 'on' Costs energy to maintain Sometimes sensible — sometimes a façade **THE AUTHENTIC SELF** What's real when the performance stops Your actual values and struggles Doesn't cost energy to be Where you actually live

The **Performance Tax**: the wider the gap, the more it costs. You've been paying it without an itemized bill.

▲ SAFETY & ESCALATION — READ CLOSELY

★ PPRA-style, sensitive, and personal — it asks your teen to examine the gap between their public and private selves. In school a counselor is briefed in advance. At home: keep it private and calm. **A well-rehearsed gap at 9–10 often sits on shame.** A teen who performs effortlessly may be the one paying the highest tax. Stay warm; don't pry. **If something heavy surfaces beneath the façade,** receive it gently and consider looping in your counselor. 988 is on the front page if you ever need it.

✦ PARENT REFLECTION

Where is my teen paying the heaviest Performance Tax — and is home truly a place the brand switches off? What does the size of their gap tell me?

END OF FREE PREVIEW

That was Lesson 1 of 4 units • 28 lessons.

The free preview ends here — you've just read the parent's letter, the orientation, the crisis & safety reference, and the first complete lesson, exactly as a family would use it at the kitchen table. The rest of the year continues in the same shape: one complete lesson per spread, in any order you like.

- ◆ Every lesson built from the same six parts — once you know one, you know them all.
- ◆ The Autism Lens on every lesson: Make It Literal, Sensory Regulation, and Universal Design for Communication.
- ◆ Elite conversation starters tagged to the real moments of a day — each with a script to model first.
- ◆ Printable anchor charts and home tools, plus a Safety & Escalation band and a Parent Reflection on every lesson.

Take it home.

The complete The Façade Home Edition — all 4 units • 28 lessons, undiluted — is available in the Store. A check-in, not an exam; a curriculum, not a worksheet.